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As the third seed, Humpy retained her Candidates spot from the previous edition. Going by her head-to-head record against the seven other contenders, Humpy's prospects look very bright.

knockout format, in 2022. Going entirely by her head-to-head record against the seven other contenders, Humpy's prospects look very bright. She won the only decisive game against top seed Aleksandra Goryachkina and has a 4-0 record against second-seeded defending champion Lei Tingjie.

Even against fourth seed Kateryna Lagno (3-1) and fifth seed Tan Zhongyi (4-0) Humpy has a clear psychological edge. Though she needs to improve her narrow 4-5 record against Anna Muzychuk, Humpy will be keen to prove her superiority over the last two lower-rated players — R. Vaishali and Nurgyul Salimova.

For the record, Humpy and Vaishali have been involved in a

drawn game while the experienced Indian is yet to face the 20-year-old Salimova.

Since the format allows a player to face the other twice, once with each colour, Humpy is expected to do well. Her vast experience should come in handy in a field that has a fine mix of players, young and seasoned. Preparation is the key in events and Humpy is known to be a keen student. What is truly heartening to note is that she has lost none of the spark of the past when she made a comeback after becoming a parent.

She has the patience needed to do well in the classical format. Her consistency is testimony to her determination to give her best each time. No wonder, she stands third in

As dependable as ever: Humpy has the game to deal with any challenge on a chess board. LENNART OOTES

the all-time list of women players with the highest rating. Only Judit Polgar (2735), who tops the list, and Hou Yifan (2687) are ahead of Humpy (2625).

So overall, Humpy enters the field knowing that she has a great chance to make this opportunity count. It is all about getting the right momentum for her campaign. Of the five Indian Candidates in Toronto, Humpy has the best chance of returning home as a World championship challenger.

R. Vaishali: She is the surprise package. In a field where the top six